THE DEFENCE IMPERATIVE

For decades, the armed forces have relied on Cheetah and Chetak helicopters—French-origin workhorses manufactured under licence in India by state-owned Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL). Over 600 of these platforms are now nearing the end of their service lives.

The urgent need to replace the old machines is most visible in the Reconnaissance and Surveillance Helicopter (RSH) programme. Originally launched in 2008, the project has regained momentum following a fresh Request for Information (RFI) issued by the Union ministry of defence in 2025, valued at an estimated Rs 15,000-20,000 crore. The requirement is for 200 light helicopters for high altitude operations—120 for the Indian Army and 80 for the Indian Air Force. The emphasis is on Make in India through a joint venture between an Indian and foreign firm. The competition for the RSH programme reflects the frenetic activity in the sector.

Airbus Helicopters, for instance, will produce its H125 single-engine, light utility, high-altitude helicopters from 2027 through a joint venture with TASL, with a final assembly line being set up in Vemagal, Karnataka, which was inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and French President Emmanuel Macron in February. As the first helicopter assembly line involving



H125

World's best-selling light helicopter, this single-engine, high-altitude machine has both military (H125M) and civil versions. Has landed on Mt Everest

TOP SPEED: 252 kmph
RANGE: 630 km
MANUFACTURER: Airbus, France
INDIAN PARTNER: Tata Advanced Systems Ltd (TASL); plan to provide copters for the Reconnaissance and Surveillance Helicopter (RSH) programme

Dhruv NG

Civil version of the ALH Dhruv. A twin-engine, multi-role rotorcraft that can carry 9-14 passengers. Ideal for connectivity and emergency services. Maiden flight in Dec. 2025

TOP SPEED: 285 kmph
RANGE: 630 km
MANUFACTURER: HAL





AW 169M

Twin-engine, multi-role helicopter ideal for 'high and hot' conditions in a variety of military roles. Has civil version

TOP SPEED: 306 kmph
RANGE: 785 km
MANUFACTURER: Leonardo S.p.A, Italy
INDIAN PARTNER: Adani Defence & Aerospace, expected to offer the machine for the NUH programme

Multi-role, twin engine helicopter designed for surveillance, search and rescue, coastal security. Of 6 ordered by MoD, 4 delivered to Coast Guard in April

TOP SPEED: 295 kmph
RANGE: 630 km
MANUFACTURER: HAL

Bell 407GXi



High-performance, single-engine light helicopter ideal for tactical missions. Has civil version

TOP SPEED: 259 kmph
RANGE: 624 km
MANUFACTURER: Bell Textron, US
INDIAN PARTNER: Max Aerospace and Aviation; has proposed assembly line for RSH programme